The Rite of the Clay Image

Toh 1279 · Derge Tengyur
ལུང་ཚ་ཆོ་ག

The Rite of the Clay Image, known in Tibetan as Tsatsé Choga and using the Indic word sāccha for the small molded clay images and votive stupas that Tibetans call tsatsa, is a very brief anonymous ritual text in verse. It explains how to make such an image: the clay is imagined through one's own deity yoga as the five precious substances, love and compassion are generated toward all beings, the deities of the three families are recalled, and the image is understood as a likeness of the dharmakāya made for the benefit of beings. It then gives a dhāraṇī addressed to Vairocana, to be recited twenty-one times over the clay, and directs that the image be consecrated with the mantra of dependent origination. It is Toh 1279 in the Tengyur, where it belongs among the short ritual works gathered with the commentaries on the tantras.

Herein is The Rite of the Clay Image (Sāccha).

As for the stages of making a clay image:
having made clay from earth,
through the yoga of one's own deity
imagine the clay as the five kinds of precious substance.
Then toward all sentient beings
one should generate love and compassion,
and call to mind the deities of the three families as well.
One sets up an image of the dharmakāya,
and that, too, for the sake of sentient beings.
Then, upon the clay,
the mantra should be cast twenty-one times:

na mo bha ga ba te bai ro ca na ta thā ga tā ya arha te samya ksaṃ budhā ya tadya thā oṃ su kṣme kṣme sa ma ya sa ma ye śā nte dā nte a sa ma ro pe a na la mbe ta raṃ be ya śo ba ti ma hā te ja ni ra ku le ni rbā ṇi sarba ta thā ga ta a dhi ṣṭhā na a dhi ṣṭhi te svā hā

With the mantras of dependent origination
the consecration is to be performed.

It is complete.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.